

Lakes of the world

There are lakes on every continent, even in high mountain ranges and deep underground. Some lakes are little more than shallow, salty pools that may dry out altogether in summer. Others are vast inland seas, or deep rifts in Earth's crust that are filled with cold, dark water.

Lake Baikal

Southern Siberia

Location Russian Federation

Area 12,160 sq miles (31,500 sq km)

Maximum depth 5,716 ft (1,741 m)

Elevation 1,500 ft (456 m) above sea level

Long and narrow, Lake Baikal occupies the deepest rift in Earth's continental crust. It was formed 25 million years ago and is the world's oldest lake. The water is four

times as deep as New York's Empire State Building, and the lake bed lies above a very deep layer of sediment that is about 4.3 miles (7 km) thick.



Lake Superior

North America



Location US-Canada border

Area 51,159 sq miles (82,367 sq km)

Maximum depth 1,333 ft (406 m)

Elevation 600 ft (183 m) above sea level

Lake Superior is the largest freshwater lake on Earth—so large that it is like an ocean. It is one of the five Great Lakes of North America, created by ice hollowing out the landscape during the last ice age. The Great Lakes were once one lake, but when the heavy mass of ice melted, the land rose up and divided them.



Caspian Sea

Central Asia

Location Longest border is with Kazakhstan

Area 143,000 sq miles (371,000 sq km)

Maximum depth 3,120 ft (950 m)

Elevation 100 ft (30 m) below sea level

Once part of the Mediterranean Sea, the Caspian Sea was cut off when sea levels fell during the last ice age. Its water is still salty, and in places much saltier than the oceans. This is because it has no outflow, so the salty minerals carried into it by the Volga

and Ural Rivers have nowhere to go. Northern areas of the sea freeze in winter.

▼ INLAND SEA

The Caspian Sea is shallowest in the north, where it forms part of Kazakhstan's coastline.

